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Two-way communication, symmetry, negative spaces, and dialogue

Michael L. Kent [a,*], Anne Lane [b]

[a] University of New South Wales, Australia
[b] Queensland University of Technology, Australia

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ABSTRACT

This paper challenges four assumptions in the public relations literature about dialogue: first, that dialogue means two-way communication; second, that dialogue is the same as two-way symmetry; third, that dialogue is the right answer to any troubled communication situation, and finally, fourth, the assumption that everyone agrees dialogue is a specific form of communication characterized by particular tenets, and with a long and distinguished ancestry reaching back to Ancient Greece. The four assumptions mean that over the last decade, dialogue has been implicitly and explicitly treated as both a panacea for public relations, and a practice that is impractical and too difficult to use. This article attempts to reconcile the various dialogic perspectives by specifying the tenets of dialogue, and using them to explain why two-way communication and two-way symmetry are *not* dialogue. We then challenge the normative bias in current conceptualizations of dialogue in public relations by identifying the existence of what we call "negative spaces," or contexts, where dialogue is not possible or appropriate.

1. Two-way communication, symmetry, negative spaces, and dialogue

A review of the research on dialogue in public relations reveals two major problems: the first problem is the understanding that *scholars* have of what dialogue is, and how they therefore should interpret and apply dialogic theory in their research. The second problem, related to the first, is that *communication professionals* also misunderstand dialogue as a result of how it is taught to students and emerging professionals in the classroom. Dialogue is often positioned in the research as a normative or idealized concept with few real-life examples of how to use it, a conclusion reached by scholars such as Ihlen and Levenshus (2017), and Meisenbach and Feldner (2009). At the same time, however, dialogue is also assumed to be a staple communication approach suitable for every situation, a panacea for stakeholder engagement and damaged relationships, and a communication tool that all professionals instinctively know how to use—also a point of contention for some scholars (cf., Stoker & Tusinski, 2006).

This article addresses the misperceptions about dialogue (cf., Kent & Theunissen, 2016; Paquette, Sommerfeldt, & Kent, 2015; Taylor, Kent, & Xiong, 2019) by taking a Protagorean approach (https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/protagoras) (being able to argue both sides of an issue; learning to make the weaker issue the stronger), focusing on the places where one would not expect to find dialogue, as a means of illustrating what dialogue actually is. To highlight the inconsistency with which the term "dialogue" has been used in the public relations literature, the article draws a distinction between a genuine, normative, approach to dialogue that views dialogue as both an ethical process and a moral product (cf., Kent & Taylor, 1998), and the less rigorous approaches that assume dialogue happens whenever organizations and publics communicate with each other.

Lane (2020) suggests that taking a stand against the co-opting of the term "dialogue" by various forms of two-way communication is fighting a losing battle. She argues that the cooption can be resolved by acknowledging "the existence of different forms of 'dialogue,' ranging from the conduct of simple two-way communication through more interactive forms culminating in true (or capital D) Dialogue" (p. 1). In this article, we take the position that "dialogue" refers to the form of communication that displays high levels of ethical, honest, empathetic, inclusive, and trustworthy communication. We note that dialogue is often confused and conflated with forms of two-way communication that tend to be characterized by efforts to achieve organizational goals — what Kent and Theunissen (2016) call D-I-N-O, or dialogue in name only. In taking a strong stance on the use of the word "dialogue," we seek to challenge the conflation that occurs between the academically technical and the everyday vernacular uses of the word.

As we explain below, theorists in public relations often talk about the attributes and merits of true dialogue, while failing to provide examples of

* Corresponding author.
E-mail addresses: MichaelLKent@gmail.com (M.L. Kent), A.Lane@qut.edu.au (A. Lane).

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less rigorous forms of dialogue as D-I-N-O, or simple two-way communication. Research by Lane (2014a, 2014b), has identified that the application of the term "dialogue" to instances of two-way communication leads to the misunderstanding that dialogue takes place everywhere, and in any two-way communicative situation. Instances of two-way communication in public relations practice being described as dialogue are relatively easy to find, and lead to the confusion over the normative status of dialogue. Genuine dialogue is uncommon and is difficult or impossible to create strategically. Our goal in the remainder of this article is to clearly delineate the boundaries between the conduct of genuine dialogue and two-way communication, by focusing on what we call "Negative Spaces," or situations where genuine dialogue is not actually possible or appropriate. Defining the boundaries of dialogue also allows us to better characterize the contexts, purposes, and applications appropriate to dialogic theory.

To achieve our goals, we first briefly review dialogic theory and what the actual theoretical assumptions are of dialogue by drawing upon communication theory and rhetorical sources, and original treatments by public relations scholars of dialogue. Section two of the essay examines the "normative bias" and normative theory in dialogic research. The third section of the essay explains the issue of where dialogue is *not* appropriate and where dialogue *does not* (and arguably *cannot*) happen. Section three also takes up the issue of dialogue as an ontological theory rather than an empirical one. Finally, section four offers suggestions for how to explore and use dialogue more fully in public relations research and how professionals can do more with dialogic theory.

2. The roots of dialogue

The impact of the concept of dialogue on research in public relations cannot be overstated. Dialogue has become one of the most utilized, tested, and influential theories/concepts in public relations to emerge over the last two decades, having been used in thousands of articles, theses, dissertations, chapters, and other scholarly works (Morehouse & Saffer, 2018). At the same time, dialogue has also been one of the most abused and misapplied concepts in public relations, with scholars feeling the need to offer explanations of the distinctions between dialogue and dialogic (Taylor & Kent, 2014), D-I-N-O or "dialogue in name only" (Kent & Theunissen, 2016), rhizomatous dialogue (Kent & Lane, 2017); and even between lowercase **d**ialogue and uppercase **D**ialogue (Lane, 2020). There are also many scholars who presume that various social media are dialogic merely because of the presence of two-way communication (Baird & Parasnis, 2011; Briones, Kuch, Liu, & Jin, 2011; Smith, 2010). In addition, research has identified issues with how public relations practitioners understand and apply dialogue in their work (Lane & Bartlett, 2016), and what various dialogic theorists have to say about dialogic approaches (Capizzo, 2018). The first section of this essay begins by briefly reviewing the characteristics of dialogue, and then introducing and critiquing two dialogic fallacies often repeated by public relations scholars—that dialogue is just two-way communication (including talk), and that dialogue is an extension of symmetrical theory.

2.1. Tenets of genuine dialogue

Table 1 presents an overview of recent *Public Relations Review* articles on dialogue based on keywords, titles, content, etc. The articles were analyzed for the underlying author assumptions (how they write about or describe dialogue in their essay, such as examining two-way asymmetrical exchanges: tweets, etc., as dialogue rather than as mere conversation or talk, or assuming that all exchanges are dialogue simply by nature of people interacting), definition, research approach, and what media/texts were examined about dialogue (face to face interactions, virtual interactions via social media, textual exchanges, surveys, etc.). The articles were also categorized as being mainly positivist (creating knowledge through observations and descriptions of tangible phenomena) or normative (focusing on how things could/should/might be). Although we acknowledge that the analysis is subjective, Table 1 nonetheless reveals the diversity of approaches in the literature.

Table 1
Analysis of Recent Articles on Dialogue in Public Relations.

Author	Definition	Assumptions	Review Theory	Qual./Quant.	Media Exam.	Norm/Pos
Abitbol and Lee (2017)	Kent & Taylor	Dialogue = Talk	Yes	Qual	Social Media	P
Avidar (2017)	K & T/Taylor & Kent•	Engagement/Talk	No	Quant	Social Media	P
Byrum (2017)	Various	Ethical/Dialogue = Talk	Yes	Qual	Text	P
Capizzo (2018)	Bakhtinian	Understanding	Yes	Qual	F2F/Text	N
Cardwell, Williams, Pyle (2017)	K & T/Various	Strategic/Instrumental/Tool	Yes	Qual	F2F	N
Chen, Hung-Baesecke, et al. (2020)	None	Dialogue = Talk	No	Quant	Social Media	P
Dhanesh (2017)	Taylor & Kent	Engagement	Yes	Qual	Critical†	P
du Plessis (2018)	Kent & Taylor	Dialogue = Talk	Yes	Quant*	Social Media	P
Gálvez-Rodríguez et al. (2018)	Kent & Taylor	Dialogue = Talk/Dialogic	Yes	Quant‡	Social Media	N
Gesualdi (2019)	Kent & Taylor	Dialogue = Talk	Yes	Qual	Critical†	N
Jelen-Sanchez (2017)	Taylor & Kent	NA§	No	Quant	Text	P
Kent and Lane (2017)	K & T/Pearson/Buber	Orientation/Complex	Yes	Qual	Critical†	N
Lane (2018)	Kent & Taylor	2-way, positive regard	Yes	Qual	F2F	N
Magen and Lapid (2018)	None	Dialogue = Talk	No	History	Text	P
Palenchar, Heath, Levenshus, Lemon (2017)	Kent & Taylor	Ethical/Dialogue = Talk	Yes	Qual	Critical†	N
Place (2019)	None	Dialogue = Talk	No	Qual	F2F	P
Ruck, Welch, Menara (2017)	Kent & Taylor	Dialogue = Talk	Yes	Quant	Text/Survey	P
Smith, Smith, and Knighton (2018)	Co-creation/Public Exp.	Dialogue/Crisis	Yes	Mixed	Social Media	P
Toledano et al. (2017)	Buberian	Dialogue/Persuasion	Yes	Qual	Text	N/P
Watkins (2017)	Kent & Taylor	Strategic/Instrumental/Tool	Yes	Quant	Social Media	P

Articles were selected based on current or in press articles on dialogue obtained from* Public Relations Review *available during an earlier draft of the manuscript.

• **Note:** Kent and Taylor (K&T) and Taylor and Kent have written numerous articles together. When the table refers to K&T, it is to the earlier work of the pair (1998, 2002). References to Taylor and Kent are to their later article on engagement from 2014. Their definitions do not change, but the 2014 article expanded on earlier work.

* Note: du Plessis calls her study qualitative, however, the methods of analysis all seem quantitative: social media content, machine generated key words, word cloud generated graphics, machine generated clusters, etc.

† Note: Although most critical methods are qualitative, conducting a "critical review of literature" is quite different than textual analysis or examining social media tweets. Burke (1973) called "cluster analysis" a quantitative method, for example.

‡ Note: del Mar Gálvez-Rodríguez, et al. call their approach qualitative, but items are counted, and results calculated based on a mathematical formula. There seems to be little to no critical reflection associated with qualitative analysis.

§ Note: Jelen-Sanchez does not study dialogue per se but reports its prevalence and interaction in engagement research.

The absence of a consistent frame of reference or understanding of dialogue revealed in Table 1 challenges the assumption in public relations that everyone knows what dialogue is. The table shows that some scholars do not even define dialogue or review *any* relevant theories in their work, perhaps on the mistaken assumption that "everyone already knows" what dialogue is. The lack of theoretical context means scholars have therefore not acknowledged the rich history of dialogue as an academic topic of interest in their research and theorizing; and implies some scholars might not be aware of the existence of the body of scholarly thought on dialogue and its relevance to their work. The frequency of positivist perspectives also provides support for our contention that scholars frequently claim to have observed dialogue when, in fact, their study considers other phenomena, such as talk or engagement. Although we are not arguing that a positivist approach to the study of dialogue is impossible, the nature of positivist research makes studying experiential phenomena more difficult.

The roots of dialogue are complex. Dialogue has evolved as a communicative practice in public relations and been adopted by different scholars in a variety of disciplines, such as political science and organizational communication (Pieczka, 2011). Dialogue has been examined as an activity that is philosophical (Plato, 1999), interpersonal (Anderson et al., 1994; Buber, 1923), ethical and moral (Buber, 1923; Laing, 1961; Noddings, 1984), and that facilitates meaning making (Bakhtin, 1991; Capizzo, 2018; Gadamer, 1975/2004). Dialogue has been positioned as a psychological orientation (Laing, 1961; Rogers, 1956), a tool for combatting oppression (Freire, 1970), a way of connecting individuals to form a greater whole (Bohm, 2006), a tool for better democracy and political participation (Habermas, 1984; Kent, 2013), and as a more ethical public relations tool (Kent & Taylor, 2002), among other purposes.

Dialogue is also used by scholars in all disciplines: learning and education (Innes, 2007), business, accounting, marketing (Bebbington, Brown, Frame, & Thomson, 2007), computers and collaborative learning (Koschmann, 1999; Wegerif & Major, 2018), and many other fields. Summaries of dialogic theory are readily available in communication and public relations (cf. Anderson et al., 1994; Johannesen, 1996; Kent & Taylor, 2002; etc.). Below we present an overview of dialogue for ease of reference, and to show the roots of the tenets of dialogue proposed in the next section.

The direct descendent of the classic form of dialogue (and therefore arguably the closest to that pure conceptualization) is what Bohm (2006) labelled capital D Dialogue, and what has also been referred to as true or genuine dialogue. Key principles of dialogue include: Risk, Trust, Positive Regard, Mutuality, Propinquity, Empathy, Commitment, Authenticity, Psychological Readiness, and others.

While the academic literature acknowledges the existence of deficit forms of dialogue, such as Buber's (Buber, 1923) *I-It*, Bohm's (2006) upper and lowercase d versions, and Davidson's (2016) "shallow" dialogue (Lane, 2020), what has not characterized the scholarship on dialogue has been a procedural focus that sees dialogue as a way to get one's way or persuade others. Indeed, the idea of using dialogue strategically or manipulatively to get one's way is antithetical to dialogue (Kent & Taylor, 2002). Additionally, we only see attempts to use dialogue strategically by contemporary business and public relations scholars, but not in the primary literature (Kent & Theunissen, 2016).

Some scholars position dialogue as a tool to serve the interests of legacy management theories, such as situational theories (cf., Chen, Hung-Baesecke et al., 2020; Cheng, Shen, & Jiang, 2020; Ni, Xiao, Liu, & Wang, 2019), rather than treating dialogue as having its own body of concepts. Other scholars have consistently sought to treat dialogue as simply a synonym for talk (cf. Grunig, 2009; Grunig & Grunig, 1996; Grunig, Grunig, & Ehling, 1992), which affords it no special status as a theoretical concept, an issue taken up next.

2.2. Two-way communication or "talk" vs. genuine dialogue

Above, we claim that taking a stand against mistaking two-way communication for dialogue is justified. Worth noting is that there is nothing wrong with studying the practice of two-way communication. In fact, two-way communication is a vital precursor to the conduct of dialogue (Lane, 2020). However, reducing dialogue to either talk or two-way communication essentially diminishes a theory that emerged thousands of years ago as a means of discovering truth and treating people with "unconditional positive regard" (Rogers, 1956; cf., also Buber, 1923), to the status of handmaiden to a management-centric theory whose primary interest is to advance organizational interests, and that treats stakeholders and publics strategically, as means to organizational ends. Clarifying the relationship between two-way communication and dialogue before fully defining what dialogue *means* is essential, considering the number of studies that continue to erroneously assume dialogue is just a type of two-way communication, and the number of author's who keep arguing dialogue is more (cf., Kent & Theunissen, 2016; Lane & Kent, 2018; Sommerfeldt & Yang, 2018; Theunissen, 2015; Theunissen & Wan Noordin, 2012).

"Dialogue" is often assumed to happen whenever there is conversation or communicative interaction (cf., du Plessis, 2018; Place, 2019), and many scholars use the word "dialogue" informally with no mention of the abundant theoretical scholarship. Dialogue is an ontological orientation that involves a communicative give and take between two or more individuals who positively regard each other and their communication. Two-way communication that involves a "communicative give and take" between two or more individuals (Kent & Taylor, 1998), but is used for self-interested information gathering is strategic and not dialogic. Dialogue also represents a more formalized practice of communication that privileges trust, truth, understanding, and an assortment of other factors. Thus, when a scholar speaks of dialogue as a synonym for talk (interchange, discussion, negotiation, conversation, talk, etc.), they inappropriately lay claim to the success of dialogue as a process of understanding and learning about others (Bakhtin, 1991; Buber, 1923; Gadamer, 1975/2004; Taylor & Kent, 2014, etc.). In practice, dialogue is more about understanding and co-orientation than about exchanging information, everyday talk, or chit-chat. For these reasons, the assumption that two-way communication conducted online and particularly on social media platforms, is dialogue is also mistaken (cf., Watkins, 2017).

We are not suggesting that scholars must be constrained in their word choices, but when those choices involve words that are steeped in ideological baggage and theory (McGee, 1980; McGee & Martin, 1983), an acknowledgement such as "dialogue is being used here in the vernacular sense as a synonym for talk" seems in order. Scholars damage the theoretical meaning of dialogue when they assume that an everyday communicative interaction represents anything more than a bilateral exchange of information.

Another misperception of dialogue often seen in contemporary literature is that it equates to two-way symmetry. The reason why assuming that achieving "mutual understanding" indicates the occurrence of dialogue are presented next.

2.3. Two-way symmetry and dialogue

Two-way symmetrical communication, introduced to public relations by Grunig and Hunt (1984) and Grunig et al. (1992), talks about two-way communication that considers the interests of both the organization and publics. The two-way communication and apparent mutual accommodation at the heart of two-way symmetric public relations have meant symmetry is often mixed up with dialogue (see, for example, Cheng, 2018; Stoker & Tusinski, 2006).

Grunig (2001) seems to provide justification for the conflation of dialogue with two-way symmetry when he states that the purpose of two-way symmetrical communication is for public relations practitioners to "bring

about symbiotic changes in the ideas, attitudes, and behaviors of both their organizations and publics" (p. 12). While a superficial reading might result in the mixing up of two-way symmetry with dialogue, a deeper consideration shows this should not be the case. Returning to the original source material, Grunig and Hunt (1984) clearly state although the purpose of this "symbiosis" is to achieve "mutual understanding between organizations and their publics" (p. 22), the ultimate aim of is for "practitioners to learn how the public perceives the organization and to determine what consequences the organization has for the public" (p. 25). In other words, two-way symmetry focuses on determining what organizations have to do to gain approval—or even acquiescence—from their stakeholders. The "mutual understanding" is really only about establishing the existence and extent of non-negotiable boundaries for participants; and how organizations can maneuver around them to achieve their desired outcomes.

Worth noting is that Grunig never used the phrase "symmetrical dialogue" in his work. More importantly, the word "dialogue" does not appear at all in Grunig's (2008) "Excellence Theory in Public Relations" encyclopedia entry, and the word dialogue does not appear in the Grunig et al. (1992) "Excellence" book until page 58. Indeed, throughout that lengthy book, the word dialogue only appears about a dozen times (in five sections), and apart from one reference to Habermasian dialogue (akin to public debate), Grunig and others' notion of dialogue is limited in intent to meaning "talk," or seen as a tool for meeting organizational objectives. As Grunig et al. (1992) explain:

> The exploratory phase of the discussion allows participants to define the nature of the dialogue through their responses to very broad questions. Participants might be asked: "What comes to mind when I say 'ecology'?" This is followed by the probing phase, where *dialogue* is guided to more narrow topic areas of interest to the researcher. (p. 192, emphasis added)

The "guided dialogue" approach and the privileging of the researchers' interests is not consistent with the tenets of genuine dialogue.

The sublimation of dialogue into two-way symmetry has been positioned as one of the reasons why the theorizing of dialogue in public relations has not progressed as might have been anticipated (Pieczka, 2011). Theunissen and Wan Noordin (2012) contend that the uncritical equation of dialogue and two-way symmetrical communication "has not done justice to the nature of dialogue, and has effectively stifled concrete development of a dialogic theory in public relations" (p. 5).

The conclusion of the above section is that t*wo-way symmetrical communication is not inherently dialogic, and dialogue is more than an offshoot of two-way communication*. Having established these perspectives, the next section takes up the issue of the "normative bias" that characterizes many critiques of dialogue in public relations.

3. The normative bias in dialogic theories of public relations

For more than a decade, scholars critical of dialogic public relations have suggested that dialogue was impractical, and that dialogue was "just" a normative theory (Huesca, 2000, 2008; Paquette et al., 2015; Tufte & Mefalopulos, 2009; Waters, 2000). Indeed, those more focused on practice often deride normative theories as insufficient or inadequate to prepare future professionals. Macnamara, Zerfass, Adi, and Lwin (2018)) cite Robert Craig's claim that "normative theory does not go far enough in informing a field" (p. 708) that is as practical as public relations. However, we argue that normative theories have an important role in practical disciplines. They ask us to acknowledge the existence of ways of thinking, being, and doing that are better for the greater good. Normative theories challenge us to be better than we might normally be. Professional codes of ethics/practice are largely informed by normative theories; normative theories describe a world where things get better for all stakeholders and publics; and *normative theories are more ethical*, as Burke (cf. 1966) suggests of moral versus "Scientistic" approaches.

3.1. The role of theory is knowledge creation

One of the major flaws at the heart of the critiques of dialogic theory's normative bias is the perception that dialogic theory is based on an often-tacit assumption that dialogue is universally applicable. That is not the case. Dialogic scholars have argued that dialogue has a place in public relations, but they also recognize that with dialogue, one size does not fit all. However, little attention has been paid to the corollary: that not all public relations needs to be or should/could be dialogic (Lane, 2018). Crisis situations, for example, call for quick and decisive action, so they are not suitable for the deliberateness of a dialogic approach—although dialogue might be appropriate in latter crisis stage. However, other organizational settings and situations, such as issues management—a process that is often undertaken to avoid crises—present perfect opportunities for dialogue because of the slower speed at which decisions are made. Dialogue could be employed in many ways as part of an issues management process. The important point to remember here is that the situation, environment, and constraints all play a role in determining the best approach to communication.

(Mis)uses of the label "dialogue" often position it as a panacea, or appropriate dialogue as a disguise to hide unpalatable truths about organizational behavior. As Capizzo (2018) explains:

> The guise of dialogue may be used as a panacea to mask less desirable motives and processes (Heath et al., 2006). Dialogue-in-name-only permits organizations to benefit from the appearance of dialogue without embracing its principles (Kent & Theunissen, 2016; Paquette et al., 2015). In these ways, the popularity of dialogue (along with its ambiguity), have created an environment where it can be difficult for lay audiences and even experts to distinguish genuine from insincere approaches. (p. 525).

Normative theorists do not assume that dialogue is appropriate everywhere. Additionally, as discussed previously, much of the research on dialogue has actually only considered two-way communication, which is much more widespread. The "two-way = dialogue" approach has given the false impression that occurrences of dialogue must therefore be ubiquitous.

Based on our negative spaces perspective, when the context being examined (social media in most cases) just focuses on two-way exchanges of talk (as illustrated in Table 1), and the substance or content of those conversations does not actually play any relevant role in analysis or theorizing, we see a negative dialogic space. Although discovering that dialogue is happening in social media (Facebook, Twitter, WeChat, YouTube, etc.) is hypothetically possible and many are interested in discovering how (Table 1), what we find in most cases (as Table 1 and other research cited suggest) are two-way communicative exchanges being described as dialogue. This matters because, as pointed out above, two-way communication (both asymmetrical and symmetrical) is an organization-centric approach designed to achieve organizational goals. Dialogue is about mutual understanding and does not involve using conversations to achieve organizational goals. There is of course nothing wrong with communication professionals working to achieve organizational goals. However, achieving those goals through the use of two-way communication does not demonstrate the universality of dialogue.

The approach or perspective that one takes to dialogue largely dictates what one will see, and what one will find. If one assumes that dialogue is simply a procedural conversation of two-way interaction, a "ticking the box" or public meeting type of approach will be employed (Lane, 2014a, 2014b, 2018). Similarly, an approach to dialogue that sees it as useful in interpersonal contexts might lead to an engagement orientation (Lane & Kent, 2018; Taylor & Kent, 2014). The more important issue is understanding the limitations of the approach taken, and whether genuine dialogue is being explored.

Having explored the normative bias, as well as the difference between two-way communication and genuine dialogue, the next section

of the essay will explore the instances where dialogue is not appropriate and, as will be shown, where dialogue (despite claims to the contrary) does not happen. As the title of this essay suggests, we examine two "Negative Spaces": those situations where "dialogue" is not actually examined but the author(s) refer to what is being studied as dialogue, and those situations where dialogue is not possible or appropriate. Both areas are clarified below.

4. Where is dialogue not appropriate and where does dialogue not happen?

In practice, and given the nature of how scholars have written about dialogue for the last century, treating dialogue simply as any form of two-way communication or interactive talk is not accurate. Many variables influence how scholars think about dialogic public relations from *contexts* (public, quasi-public, private [Kent & Taylor, 2018], online, social media spaces, etc.); *the size/scope of group interactions* (interpersonal interactions, small group settings, public venues, large groups etc.); *recalcitrant/angry/uncooperative* (activists, rabid partisans, angry crowds, those unwilling to change, etc.); *non-dialogic issues* (the nature of an issue is not dialogic, an issue is fact based not opinion based, etc.).

We propose that the potential for dialogue to occur is linked to the impact of the variables above. For example, interpersonal, face-to-face, situations are of course the dialogic ideal (Buber, 1923/1970; Buber, 1923), so all dialogic concepts are possible in such contexts. Similarly, small group contexts are often, but not always, face to face, so some group contexts have great dialogic *potential* (Bohm, 2006); however, there is no guarantee that small groups will engage in substantive interpersonal dialogue. Additionally, most virtual group meetings are not conducive to dialogue because of the inability to effectively engage on the interpersonal level in any rich or substantive way. Because group contexts vary so widely from close colleagues/friends interacting to near strangers in a corporate setting, group interactions have the *potential* for dialogue but might not also display any dialogic features. The fact that most interactions do not rise to the level of genuine dialogue might be because of time constraints, a lack of training among members, the size of the group, a lack of trust among members, or powerful members who exercise control over the group, etc. (Kent & Logan, 2020). Still, the face-to-face nature of groups means that they have the potential to be dialogic provided the participants receive training and the group has the will to engage dialogically. Similarly, when we look at social media, certain types of interfaces possess almost no capacity for dialogic interactions in comparison to the face-to-face ideal (see Table 2 below).

Twitter, for example, is an unlikely place to try to hold a genuine dialogue as so many of the defining characteristics of dialogue are absent from Twitter—the public nature of Twitter makes it a risky place to have a controversial discussion, people come to Twitter sporadically, people make no conversational commitment to fellow interlocutors, etc.

By contrast, Facebook, which is comprised of networks of friends/colleagues/acquaintances, and generally requires permission to join, has higher potential for dialogue than Twitter because of relational and other features of Facebook.

One of our central questions then, is "where does dialogue not happen?" Apart from some of the scenarios described above, several other possibilities stand out.

4.1. How to tell when there is no dialogic potential

In virtually every study of dialogue on social media, there is a presupposition that dialogue exists or is possible, revealed in questions like "how dialogic is X. . ." or "what is the dialogic potential of Y. . ." or "how is dialogue used in social media Z. . ." The problem with such approaches is that they assume *a priori* that dialogue *is* taking place in the situation being examined rather than first considering whether it *could* be happening. Claims of the universality of dialogue can be refuted by considering first whether there is any dialogic potential in a given context. Dialogic potential is the precursor to dialogue, what is required for dialogue to take place at all. As a first guiding principle, a situation where an individual or organization sees dialogue as an opportunity or strategy to exploit others will not demonstrate genuine dialogue. Based on this principle, the following section provides examples where there is no dialogic potential, and in which dialogue therefore cannot occur.

4.1.1. Where communication is instrumentalist

"Ticking the box" or using two-way communication instrumentally as a means to an end (Lane, 2018) is not dialogue. Dialogue is not

Table 2
Potential for Dialogic Features by Media Type.

Dialogic Category	F2F	Small Group	Twitter	Facebook	Chat Group	Text/I-Message	WeChat
Trust	•	o	o	•	–	•	o
Positive Regard	•	o	o	o	o	•	•
Risk	•	o	o	•	–	•	–
Vulnerability	•	o	–	•	•	•	–
Unanticipated Consequences	•	o	o	o	•	o	–
Strange Otherness	•	o	–	o	•	–	o
Mutuality	•	o	–	•	–	•	o
Collaboration	•	o	–	o	o	o	o
Spirit of Mutual Equality	•	o	–	o	o	–	–
Propinquity	•	o	–	–	–	–	–
Immediacy of Presence	•	o	–	o	o	o	•
Temporal Flow	•	o	–	o	o	o	•
Engagement	•	o	–	o	o	o	o
Empathy	•	o	o	•	•	o	o
Supportiveness	•	o	o	o	o	o	o
Communal Orientation	•	o	o	–	–	o	•
Confirmation	•	o	o	•	o	•	o
Commitment	•	o	–	o	–	o	o
Genuineness	•	o	o	•	o	o	•
Commitment to Conversation	•	o	–	o	–	–	–
Commitment to Interpretation	•	o	–	o	–	o	–
Authenticity	•	o	–	o	o	o	o
Psychological Readiness	•	o	–	–	–	–	–

Key: • Present or substantial; o possible or limited; – absent or uncommon.
The table categories come from the detailed summary of dialogic principles in Kent and Taylor (2002).
Note: Although some readers might not agree with the coding of each category, the table is intended only to illustrate the differences between genuine dialogue and mediated forms of dialogue.

exploitative. Thus, any time an individual or organization is in a situation where they engage in two-way communication with others to achieve organizational goals, s/he is not participating in dialogue (or Buberian dialogue as described by Kent & Taylor, 2018 and others).

A paradox exists with dialogue in the sense that wanting to engage with someone dialogically, or encourage dialogue, in order to understand someone and help them understand our own beliefs and positions is a legitimately ethical or value neutral act. But orchestrating or planning to use dialogue as a means of revealing the beliefs or values of another in order to achieve "mutual" goals, presupposes that the organization knows what the "problem" is that the organization wants to solve, and is using dialogue simply as a tool to achieve its desired goals.

Organizational paternalism further explains why two-way symmetry does not automatically equate with dialogue. As Grunig and Hunt (1984) explain: under the two-way symmetric model, the goal of an organization–public interaction should be to achieve mutual understanding, and should contain in it the possibility of change for both parties. In the next paragraph, however, Grunig and Hunt note:

> Frequently, however, neither will change attitudes or behavior. The public relations staff brings the two groups together, and, as long as both communicate well enough to understand the position of the other, the public relations effort will have been successful. (p. 23)

Although the public relations goals might have been achieved, having a dialogic exchange that treats the opportunity as a chance to achieve organizational goals, does not demonstrate the use of genuine dialogue. Grunig and Hunt's position is that symmetry is essentially a tool used to solve organizational problems, a position that is not indicative of dialogue. Two-way symmetry may be a more ethical approach than asymmetry, but when two-way communication is used primarily in service of an organizational agenda, symmetry cannot legitimately lay claim to the label of dialogue.

4.1.2. Where persuasive communication occurs

Dialogue is not a tool to influence others, it is a tool for mutual understanding. When an individual or organization is engaging in debate, negotiation, or problem solving, s/he is not engaging in dialogue. Of course, two-way communication can help people solve problems and make better decisions, but dialogue cannot be enacted in situations that treat dialogue as a strategic communication tool to persuade others so pre-determined goals can be achieved. Communication that has the intent of discerning what another thinks or feels so that messages can be developed to influence that individual or the groups that s/he belongs to, should not be called dialogue.

4.1.3. Where issues of fact are at stake

As noted above, dialogue is an experiential phenomenon. Facts are not about understanding or agreement but data and information. Using dialogue to help people understand "the facts of the situation" as a means of influence or achieving one's goals is essentially a persuasive act and does not constitute dialogue. As noted above, the two-way symmetrical approach to communication often has at its core an attempt to understand and gather, or marshal, facts for courses of action often described as "mutually beneficial." However, the choice of topics or "facts" to be discussed, and the timing of those conversations, belies the real intent—promoting an understanding of strategic facts in a way that provides organizational benefits.

4.1.4. Where there is no trust

Dialogue is not possible when parties do not trust each other, or when one party believes in his/her superiority (cf., Buber, 1923; Freire, 1970). The issue of minimizing power differentials and building trust was one that Pearson worked on throughout his career (Pearson, 1989b, 1989b; cf. also, Taylor & Kent, 2014). Maximizing trust requires the minimizing of fear and increasing willingness to take risks. Risk and trust are unlikely where there are differentials in power between participants.

4.1.5. Where power or fear reign

Issues of power and vulnerability are at the heart of why dialogue is so difficult. Risk, trust, positive regard, mutuality, authenticity, etc. are all prerequisites to dialogue. Where the consequences of risks are too high, or where people feel that they are being used, exploited, or taken advantage of, there can be no dialogue. Dialogic participants need to feel some measure of equality and trust. Where power is disproportionate, dialogue is not possible.

4.1.6. Where there is no ability and/or willingness to be changed—or to admit that you have been changed

Participants in dialogue must be open to new ideas, worldviews, and behaviors suggested by others. Engaging in two-way communication that is constrained by non-negotiable boundaries is not dialogue. Nor is dialogue occurring if participants pay lip service to change but have either no intention, or no capacity, to follow through with action (cf. Lane, 2014a, 2014b, 2018). In addition, participants in dialogue are often keen to demonstrate their mutual positive regard by showing their fellow interlocutors how their ideas have influenced each other. Communication that is transitory, or just ends after a predetermined conversation has taken place or a set end goal reached, is D-I-N-O (Kent & Theunissen, 2016).

4.1.7. Where there is no respect

Dialogue requires the mutual positive orientation of participants to each other and to the communication in which they are involved. Respect cannot occur when participants do not trust each other and the communication they are undertaking; if a person believes that others have no right to be part of a conversation because they look different, speak another language, behave in "strange" ways, or because they have a different sexual or religious orientation, there can be no dialogue. Similarly, dialogue cannot occur when participants believe the process of communication is inauthentic, excludes key voices, or has a predetermined outcome.

4.1.8. Where there is a focus on the empirical and informational rather than the ontological and experiential

As pointed out earlier, dialogue is not commensurate with talk, nor is dialogue simply two-way interaction. Dialogue is rooted in lived experience, not in rules or structure: dialogue is not about facts but about experiencing and understanding. Rather than focusing on knowledge and facts and information (the empirical), dialogue produces insights into, and understanding of, oneself and others (the ontological). Engaging in dialogue is not an information gathering exercise but an experiential and interpersonal activity.

The final section of the essay deals with some suggestions for enacting a genuine dialogue. The first stage in exploring and using dialogue is to learn what dialogue truly is, and what dialogue is not—and the importance of those distinctions.

5. Suggestions for exploring and using dialogue

If the need to distinguish dialogue from other forms of two-way communication is not recognized, then the conflation of the two will continue and the unique contribution of dialogue will be lost. Scholars and practitioners therefore need to understand dialogue before they can begin exploring it and looking for its relevance to their work.

One of the biggest challenges to achieving an understanding of dialogue is dialogue's ephemeral and spontaneous nature. Finding and deconstructing real-world examples of a theory, concept, or activity is a vital precursor to being able to recognize and recreate it later. Previous studies of, and reflection on, the meaning of dialogue will allow dialogue to be recognized when it does occur. Those who experience or observe

situations of true dialogue in their work should be encouraged to share their thoughts and reflections, perhaps through professional networks or connections with the academe.

However, true dialogue tends to occur in moments that cannot be scheduled and indeed take the participants by surprise (Cissna & Anderson, 1998, p. 74). These *dialogic moments* (Black, 2008; Katriel, 2004) often emerge from situations where there is not an orchestrated communicative interaction between participants. The provision of the right context cannot, and does not, guarantee that dialogue will occur. With that caveat in mind, a more realistic focus might be on creating communicative situations that foster the development of the individual characteristics of dialogue, rather than attempting to force dialogue to occur.

For example, organizations might hold live webcasts in which visitors can raise issues of concern and potentially engage on subjects of importance to both stakeholders and organizations, but driven by stakeholder and public interests. Similarly, internal activities such as organizational events designed to bring people together not simply to solve problems, can be an opportunity for individuals to interact in non-threatening ways and build relationships with other organizational members. Social media can be used to solicit topics and questions from visitors rather than as just a marketing tool, just as social media groups can be formed around topics or subjects of interest that are not open to everyone, providing some sense of intimacy and trust. There are of course dozens of other possibilities, but for dialogue to occur, the focus has to be on interaction and understanding not on problem solving, persuasion, or promotion/marketing.

The flashes of true dialogue, with their profound impact on those involved, provide the ideal conditions for the development of the mutual satisfaction and commitment that are the bedrock of good organization–public relationships. Dialogue is also an excellent precursor and preparation for the conduct of other more strategic and instrumentalist forms of two-way communication, and arguably can occur concurrently with them (Black, 2008).

5.1. *What prevents communication professionals from using dialogue?*

Moving dialogue from a theoretical, abstract, concept to a tangible tool has been identified as a significant obstacle in the efforts to sustain its unique identity. For many reasons, genuine dialogue has been described as too hard to carry out in practice (Lane & Bartlett, 2016; Lane, 2018). First among these reasons is the practitioners' lack of understanding of genuine dialogue and an appreciation of its usefulness to them, perhaps resulting from a lack of informed teaching about dialogue during students' degree programs, and lack of training in how to create the optimal conditions for dialogue to occur in professional training. As noted above, dialogue cannot just be made to happen, but public relations practitioners are largely responsible for providing the ideal communicative situations from which dialogic moments can be generated. The motivation to enact dialogue, however, will only come when practitioners recognize both the difference and the value of dialogue.

The second barrier to the conduct of genuine dialogue is the contexts in which practitioners seek to use it. One of the main foci of this essay has been to acknowledge the existence of situations in which it is not possible for dialogue to occur, what we are calling negative spaces in dialogue. Some situations where two-way communication is impossible involve participants who are disrespectful toward each other and unwilling to be open-minded. Hostile settings may involve the intervention of communication professionals to find points of agreement. However, agreement (or at least acquiescence) can be achieved without the attainment of mutual positive regard, empathy, and the other defining characteristics of dialogue.

Finally, practitioner use of dialogue might be precluded by the constraints within which professional communicators have to work. Dialogue cannot happen when practitioners have been tasked with convincing stakeholders to accept organizational decisions or behavior, or to provide small-scale distractions from larger issues (for example, asking residents what they think about a new structure planned for a public space, rather than considering other uses to which that land could be put to benefit the community). Some situations, such as crises, are time-sensitive and need communication that leads to the development of rapid responses and quick decisions. Early stages of crisis situations tend to require the rapid communication of crucial information (Sommerfeldt, 2015; Thelwall & Stuart, 2007) and are therefore not appropriate contexts for dialogue, which takes time and involves multiple iterations of extended contact. However, in later stages of a crisis, there could be a role for dialogue in, for example, helping publics and stakeholders develop meaningful paths to recovery (Liu, Iles, & Herovic, 2020; Ulmer, Seeger, & Sellnow, 2007; Xu, 2018).

The existence of numerous spaces where dialogue is not appropriate, or is impossible to do, does not mean dialogue has no value in these situations. As an aspirational, normative theory, dialogue provides a framework that practitioners can use to guide their daily efforts. Striving toward the conduct of dialogue will enhance and enrich most communication situations, and lead to better outcomes for all involved.

6. Conclusion and directions forward for dialogue

Dialogue is renowned as a concept that defines its boundaries in terms of negatives—in other words, what it is *not* (Black, 2008, p. 94). Dialogue is not debate, and it is not discussion. At its heart lies the conduct of two-way communication, but dialogue is also not two-way symmetrical communication (Sommerfeldt & Yang, 2018). The focus on the negative aspects of dialogue might be in some measure responsible for the lack of understanding of what dialogue *is*. Saying dialogue is not debate or discussion does not help much if a person's familiarity with dialogue extends only to an incomplete understanding of the meaning of the word. If we were to discuss an elephant in the same way, we might say it is not a rhinoceros, it is not a carnivore, etc. but that would not really tell us anything about elephant-ness. Unfortunately, describing examples of dialogue is a lot harder than describing examples of negative spaces, and examples often tend to be obscure: "genuine conversations," "fleeting," "unconditional positive regard" etc.

As a normative paradigm, dialogue does not have to present an "all or nothing" challenge to practitioners and scholars. If we are aware of the aspirational possibilities of dialogue and aim for them in our work, shooting for the stars and missing is still acceptable. However, recognizing the existence of the negative spaces of dialogue in the real world, practitioners might choose instead to develop situations that encourage the participants involved to appreciate and empathize with each other.

Dialogic interactions often initially require the creation of structuring rules and guidelines to set participant expectations appropriately (cf., Pearson, 1989a; Taylor & Kent, 2014; Toledano et al., 2017). The purpose of such conversational instructions is to encourage the conduct of communication that is dialogue-like, with the intention that eventually, through practice and familiarity, dialogic communication could become the real thing. Researchers can look for situations to analyze against the characteristics of dialogue and discuss the extent of progress toward the normative goal. Such research would also provide insights into the barriers to conducting dialogue in practice, and the means through which these could be overcome, or at least mitigated. Underpinning any increased appreciation and application of dialogue is the need for better education of our emerging practitioners and scholars about its true nature and characteristics.

This essay has concluded that negative spaces exist within and around dialogue. Negative spaces are situations where dialogue has been claimed to exist (usually because of the existence of two-way interactions) but does not; or situations where dialogue is not possible (public venues, lack of trust, no relationship, no commitment, etc.). The first conclusion takes a stand against the co-opting of the label "dialogue"—referring to a sophisticated and nuanced form of communication with a long tradition of scholarly discussion—as simple two-way

communication. The second conclusion is a direct response to those critics who object to the "one-size-fits-all" approach they attribute to those who claim dialogue provides a normative paradigm for the discipline. There are times and places where dialogue *cannot* happen because of the specific nature of the situation. However, the normative positioning of dialogue means it is still incumbent on public relations practitioners and scholars to find ways to manage the communication involved so that progress is made toward the ideal.

Normative theories require professionals or scholars to put in more time thinking about the object of study. Professionals or scholars adopting normative theories do not do so because the principles are easier to use or examine, but because of the belief that the theoretical concepts help them make more ethical and moral decisions. If academics or professionals want to make dialogue possible, they need to put in the hard work, rather than just calling two-way communication dialogue. Understanding where dialogue is *not* possible should help people also understand where dialogue *is* possible.

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